

RAVI S SAHANI



THE STRING TRIO OF DELHI PERFORMING AT NEEMRANA FORT

and can't add to, that decides if you merited it in the first place," Nath says. Given his family came from Lahore as refugees, and that Wacziarg became an Indian rather late, he says, "It was almost like a new start for both of us. Perhaps the lack of a past involves you. When you don't have something, you want it and value it more."

That's why they also decided to develop the Neemrana name into a lifestyle experience. So, when they realised that the fruits from the orchards were being wasted on the Ramgarh property, they used it to manufacture jams. The tea plantations in Coonoor are used for a special Neemrana blend. They also plan to open their own coffee blend from the property in Coorg. At the same time, Wacziarg says, they would like to use their Neemrana and Puducherry properties as places of culture. Which is why, they have formalised The Neemrana Music Foundation.

With nearly 200 properties on file, they get at least three to four proposals every week, says Wacziarg. "But the most extraordinary of all projects is the Tijara Fort in Alwar, Rajasthan. It is a spot you can't create. It's a mixture of nature's magic and man's madness," says Nath.

And there's always a story behind a her-

itage property. Take Villa Pottipati, the ancestral home of a Reddy family in Malleswaram, Bangalore. Nath remembers when a US-based woman contacted them after staying at their Puducherry property. She told them about her ancestral home which she didn't want to sell or convert into a multi-storied building. "It was lovely, doable and small. We have put old portraits of their family on the walls. It's a part of their past and for everyone who lives there, it's a privilege to be part of their family," Nath says. It isn't about "modernising" a place, says Wacziarg. "It is a blend of keeping the past alive, without being sad or just nostalgic about it," he adds.

That is the spirit behind the group. It isn't just restoration. But restoration for re-use, says Nath. After all, "you can't live in the 21st century with 15th century amenities", he adds. That is why they have stuck to their concept of a non-hotel hotel. It isn't about jacuzzis, silk-cushioned sofas or pretending to be royalty. Nath says, "What we are talking about is simplicity and experience. It is about seeing parrots on your balcony or a million stars that you don't see in Delhi. That is Neemrana. It is the cosmos, our planet and about connecting and enhancing ourselves."

by Chitra Subramanyam

THE NEEMRANA GROUP FOLLOWS THE CONCEPT OF A NON-HOTEL HOTEL, PROVIDING AMENITIES OF THE 21ST CENTURY IN 15TH CENTURY PROPERTIES RESTORING THEM FOR RE-USE.